

the Valley of the Kings is a renowned burial site of pharaohs, featuring tombs dating from 1539 to 1075 BCE. Spread over a wide area, the complex contains a total of 64 known tombs that vary greatly in size and style. The structures were intended to be concealed within the hills to protect the pharaohs' remains and riches from looters. Generally, the interior plans of the tombs contain complex series of shafts and chambers, but only one corridor leads to the burial chamber, where a stone sarcophagus containing the royal mummy was laid. Nearly all of the tombs of the Valley of the Kings were looted in antiquity. Nevertheless, the site has been an important place of archaeological exploration since the 18th century and was made a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1979.

Lighthouse of Alexandria

Location Alexandria, Egypt

Said to have risen to a height of up to 600 ft (183 m), the Lighthouse of Alexandria (also known as the Pharos of Alexandria) was a technological marvel, considered to be one of the Seven Wonders of antiquity. It was built in around 280 BCE, during the time of the Ptolemaic Kingdom, to a design by Greek architect Sostratus of Cnidus. Ancient descriptions suggest it was built from limestone blocks, in three tapering sections built on top of one another on a base some 98 ft (30 m) square. Unfortunately, a series of earthquakes damaged and eventually destroyed the lighthouse in the 13th century. However, in 1994, archaeologists discovered its remains in Alexandria's harbor, just off the small Pharos Island.

Temple of Isis

Location Agilkia Island, Egypt

The ancient island of Philae on the River Nile, in southern Egypt's Aswan region, is renowned for its wealth of archaeological treasures. Among them is the Temple of Isis, a complex constructed in stages and eventually completed during the reign of Ptolemy III Euergetes (r.246–221 BCE). The temple is dominated by two large pylons—monumental gateways consisting of two tapering towers—decorated with carvings depicting pharaohs and gods, including Isis. The temple was partially flooded by the building of the old Aswan Dam but reemerged after 1970, when a new dam was constructed. To save the rapidly deteriorating structure from water damage, archaeologists moved the temple's ruins to the nearby Agilkia Island.

Temple of Horus

Location Edfu, Egypt

The well-preserved Temple of Horus, on the west bank of the Nile, was built in the Ptolemaic Kingdom during the Hellenistic period, between 237 and 57 BCE. Dedicated to Horus, ancient Egypt's falcon-headed god, the structure is instantly recognizable by its huge pylons, about 118 ft (36 m) high, and vibrant external decorations that include carvings depicting the deity. Beyond the pylons is a courtyard, a series of halls, and an inner sanctuary surrounded by chapels. In one of the halls, known as the Court of Offerings, stand two granite sculptures of Horus. With its simple plan along a main axis, the building is considered a classic example of an Egyptian temple.

► PYLON DECORATED WITH DETAILED CARVINGS AT THE TEMPLE OF HORUS

